PIA3121 Theories of International Relations — Week 1 Summary: Tools of Analysis / Foundational Concepts

1. Course Aims and the "Root Discourses" of IR

Keywords: root discourses, discipline of IR, concepts as tools, real-life problems, theory applied to practice

1.1 Two Objectives (Slides 2–3)

Keywords: introduce the discipline, illuminate real problems, theory–practice link

- **Objective 1:** introduce the "root discourses" of International Relations — the foundational theoretical traditions that make up IR as an academic discipline (Slide 2).
- **Objective 2:** use **concepts developed by contributors to the root discourses** to **illuminate real-life problems and issues facing the world today** (Slide 3).
- → Theory is treated as a **toolkit**, not an end in itself: every concept learned should be usable on a current case.
- One-liner: *learn the traditions, then use their concepts as lenses on today's world.*

1.2 The Nine Root Discourses (Slide 4) (memorise)

Keywords: realism, liberalism, neo-neo debate, structuralism, English School, constructivism, ontological security, critical theory, gender

- Realism
- Liberalism
- Neorealism and Neoliberalism
- Economic Structuralism
- The English School
- Constructivism
- **Psychology and** Ontological Security
- Critical Theory
- **Gender and IR** (Feminist IR)
- → These nine traditions are the "menu" of the semester; each later week develops one of them (see Section 2.2).

1.3 Real-Life Global Problems the Theories Should Illuminate (Slide 5)

Keywords: power transition, liberal order, existential risk, political economy, inequality, conflict, global governance

Six problem clusters the course returns to:

- **Systemic adjustment to the rises of China and India** — fate of the **liberal international order**; democracy and democratisation.
- **Demography, natural resources, climate change, pandemics, existential risks.**
- **Challenges to the world political economy**; technology and global communication; **AI**.
- **Women and gender (in)equality**; other forms of (in)equality; ethnic relations; religion in IR.
- **Regional inter-state tensions**; wars; civil wars; terrorism; revolution.
- **Ethics and values in a multicultural world**; global governance.

2. Course Logistics: Texts, Schedule, Readings, Assessment

Keywords: Viotti & Kauppi, Oxford Handbook, schedule, midterm quiz, group paper, assessment tasks

2.1 Required and Recommended Books (Slide 6)

Keywords: core textbook, handbook, reference texts

- Viotti & Kauppi, *International Relations Theory* (6th ed.) — core textbook; Week 1 reading is its chapter "Thinking About IR Theory".
- Reus-Smit & Snidal (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of International Relations* — source of several assigned chapters.

2.2 Schedule (Slide 7)

Keywords: weekly topics, midterm 13 Oct, final quiz, group paper 8 Dec

- **1 Sept** Tools of Analysis / Foundational Concepts
- **8 Sept** Realism
- **15 Sept** Liberalism
- **22 Sept** Neorealism and Neoliberalism
- **29 Sept** Economic Structuralism and Globalization
- **6 Oct** Constructivism
- **13 Oct — MIDTERM QUIZ** (covers Weeks 1–6)
- **20 Oct** Ontological Security Theory
- **27 Oct** The English School
- **3 Nov** Democratization / Global Culture / Revolution
- **10 Nov** Critical Theory / Gender in IR / Global Civil Society
- **17 Nov** Chaos and Complexity in IR / Existential Risks
- **24 Nov** FINAL QUIZ DUE / Discussion of Group Projects
- **8 Dec — GROUP PAPER PROJECT DUE**
- → Midterm = mainstream canon (realism → constructivism); second half = newer and critical traditions.

2.3 Reading for 8 September — Realism (Slide 8)

Keywords: realism, the state, balance of power, Lake, Wohlforth

- Viotti & Kauppi, "Realism: The State and Balance of Power," pp. 21–62.
- Lake, "The State and International Relations," in Reus-Smit and Snidal (eds.), pp. 41–61.
- Wohlforth, "Realism," in Reus-Smit and Snidal (eds.), pp. 131–149.

2.4 Assessment (Slide 9)

Keywords: assessment tasks (ATs), CILOs, final grade

- Final grade is built from **Assessment Tasks/Activities (ATs)**, which are designed to assess how well students achieve the CILOs (Course Intended Learning Outcomes) (Slide 9).

3. Tools of Analysis I: Computational Text Analysis

Keywords: R, RStudio, text mining, structural topic model, STM, People's Daily, Zhihu, AI as assistant

3.1 Software Setup (Slides 10, 22)

Keywords: R, RStudio, posit.co

- Go to posit.co → install **R** → install **RStudio** (Slides 10, 22). Course tool, not exam content.

3.2 Instructor Demo: "National Rejuvenation" in Chinese Discourse (Slides 11–16)

Keywords: minzu fuxing, People's Daily, Zhihu, topic composition, Mapper network, data as evidence

- **Slide 11:** count of *People's Daily* articles mentioning **"National Rejuvenation" (民族复兴, minzu fuxing)** — near **zero before 2000**, rising to roughly **2,500 per year by 2021–23**.
- **Slides 12–13: topic-composition charts** comparing *People's Daily* (state party newspaper) with **Zhihu** (Chinese Q&A social platform), 2012–2025.
- **Slides 14–15:** topic mass for **"rejuvenation + future"** in each source.
- **Slide 16: Mapper network** of topics — People's Daily = yellow, Zhihu = purple.
- → **Point of the demo:** large-scale text mining is a **tool of analysis** for IR — it turns discourse (e.g. national identity narratives) into measurable data.

3.3 Building a Structural Topic Model with AI Help (Slides 17–20)

Keywords: STM, stm package, quanteda, pdftools, corpus, DFM, K topics

- Structural Topic Model (STM): a statistical method that discovers latent topics in a large set of texts and lets topic prevalence vary with document metadata (e.g. news source, date) — run via the R stm package.
- AI acts as a guide through **five phases** (Slide 18):

    - **Setup and installation** — install/load packages (stm, quanteda, pdftools).
    - **Text extraction** — script to read e.g. **500 PDFs** from a folder and convert them to text.
    - **Data cleaning and pre-processing** — build the **corpus**, tokenize, remove stopwords and punctuation, produce the **document-feature matrix (DFM)**.
    - **Model fitting** — run stm(), explaining key parameters such as **K (number of topics)**.
    - **Analysis and visualisation** — topic word clouds; plotting how **topic prevalence correlates with metadata** (e.g. news source).

- Key terms:

    - Corpus: the structured collection of all texts being analysed.
    - Document-feature matrix (DFM): a "spreadsheet" with one row per document and one column per word (feature), recording word counts — the input format stm needs (Slides 19–20).

- Example interaction (Slides 19–20): texts extracted with pdftools → **quanteda** builds corpus and DFM, removing punctuation, **stopwords** and numbers and **stemming** words (*"running" → "run"*).

3.4 The Student as Research Director (Slide 21)

Keywords: technical assistant, not intellectual replacement, critical thinking, K choice, interpretation

- AI can write all the code, but its role is **technical assistant, not intellectual replacement**; the student is the **research director**.
- Tasks only the student can do (memorise the list):

1. **Define the research question.**
2. **Select and justify the text corpus.**
3. **Make crucial modelling decisions** — e.g. choosing **K**.
4. **Interpret and label the topics** from their content.
5. **Perform the final nuanced analysis** linking model output back to **IR theories** from class.

- → AI is "the exact kind of productivity-enhancing tool" students will meet in their careers; the assignment trains critical analysis, with the student "doing the driving".
- One-liner: *AI writes the code; you supply the question, the judgement and the theory.*

4. Why You Need Theory: Signal vs. Noise (Slides 23–28)

Keywords: signal-to-noise, hot-take economy, events as symptoms, unconscious theory, cognitive supremacy

Five build-up claims (Slides 24–28) for why theory is necessary:

4.1 Drowning in Data, Starving for Insight (Slide 24)

Keywords: pundits, algorithms, state narratives, information overload

- Daily bombardment by **pundits, algorithms, and state-sponsored narratives**; the **noise-to-signal ratio** is overwhelming.
- Signal: information that reveals a real, underlying change or force; noise: the mass of irrelevant, emotional or misleading information surrounding it.

4.2 The "Hot Take" Economy Will Fail You (Slide 25)

Keywords: immediacy, emotion, surface analysis, what vs why

- Surface news analysis prioritises **immediacy and emotion over structural understanding**.
- It tells you **what** happened, rarely **why**.

4.3 Events Are Symptoms, Not the Disease (Slide 26)

Keywords: underlying forces, structural causes, crisis-chasing

- *Example:* why are **semiconductor supply chains** the new frontline?
- *Example:* why is the **South China Sea militarised**?
- Focusing only on the latest crisis **blinds you to the underlying forces** driving it.
- → Theory directs attention from the event to the **cause**.

4.4 Everyone Uses Theory (Slide 27)

Keywords: pragmatism, implicit theory, conscious and rigorous theory

- Being "**pragmatic**" often just means using an **unconscious, outdated theory**.
- The course aims to make those theories **conscious, rigorous, and powerful**.
- Standard context: a theory is a simplified set of assumptions and propositions that explains and helps predict patterns — no observer can avoid using one, only choose whether to examine it (Viotti & Kauppi, "Thinking About IR Theory").

4.5 The Goal: Cognitive Supremacy (Slide 28)

Keywords: cut through noise, signals of change, independent understanding

- Cognitive supremacy: the ability to cut through the noise, identify the actual signals of change, and achieve an independent understanding of the world (memorise).
- One-liner: *theory is a filter — it separates signal from noise and explains why, not just what.*

5. The Algorithmic Society (Slides 29–32)

Keywords: algorithms, coding elite, code as law, data doubles, algorithmic dominion, autonomy, democratic governance

5.1 Algorithms Reorganise Institutions (Slide 29)

Keywords: algorithm, social institutions, computational power

- Algorithms: sets of instructions written as code and run on computers.
- The reorganisation of **social institutions** is increasingly **driven by algorithms**.

5.2 The Coding Elite (Slide 29)

Keywords: concentrated power, digital means of production, ownership

- A new "coding elite" — a group that has consolidated immense cultural, political and economic power through mastery of computational techniques and ownership claims over the digital means of production.

5.3 Code as Law (Slide 30)

Keywords: machine-readable world, automatic enforcement, exclusion, allocation

- Computer code **functions as a form of law**:
  - it **translates the world into machine-readable entities**;
  - it **automatically enforces rules, exclusions, and resource allocations**.

5.4 Data Doubles and Algorithmic Dominion (Slide 31)

Keywords: behavioural trace data, surveillance, autonomy, democracy

- **Algorithmic classifiers** continually extract **behavioural trace data** to build "data doubles" — surveillant digital profiles of individuals constructed from their behavioural traces.
- Individuals **cannot shape the terms** of this algorithmic dominion or evade **the rule of the code** → profound questions for **human autonomy** and **democratic governance**.

5.5 Infographic Summary (Slide 32)

Keywords: algorithmic governance, coding elite, new social divisions, filtered sociality

- Four linked themes: **algorithmic governance**; the **coding elite**; **new social divisions**; **filtered sociality** (social life mediated and filtered by algorithms).

6. Cultivating "Cognitive Supremacy" in the Age of AI (Slides 33–37)

Keywords: geopolitical literacy, AI-proof skills, higher-order cognition, anticipation, uncertainty

Four build-up claims for why IR theory matters for careers:

6.1 Geopolitical Literacy Is Your Competitive Advantage (Slide 34)

Keywords: international risk, opportunity, core competency

- Whether in government IR analysis, business, tech, law or journalism, the ability to **assess international risk and opportunity** is now a **core competency**.

6.2 The "AI-Proof" Skillset (Slide 35)

Keywords: automation, critical thinking, strategic thinking

- As **AI automates routine analysis**, the highest value goes to **deep, critical, and strategic thinking**.
- IR theory cultivates this **higher-order cognition**.

6.3 Anticipating the Next Move (Slide 36)

Keywords: see around corners, explanation, prediction

- The course trains you to "**see around corners**": others focus on **what** is happening; you understand **why** and **what is likely to happen next**.

6.4 Navigating Uncertainty with Confidence (Slide 37)

Keywords: frameworks, ambiguity, risk assessment, volatility

- No crystal ball — but **frameworks** to **analyse ambiguity, assess risk, and make informed decisions** in a volatile world.

7. Levels of Analysis and Anarchy (Slides 38–41)

Keywords: levels of analysis, individual, state, international system, anarchy, Earth from space, nations of the world

7.1 Framing Images (Slides 38–39)

Keywords: planetary view, world political map, units of IR

- **Slide 38:** Earth from space — one planet, no borders visible.
- **Slide 39:** world political map, "the nations of the world" — the same planet divided into sovereign states.
- → The contrast sets up IR's core puzzle: a single interdependent planet governed by many separate states with no authority above them.

7.2 The Levels-of-Analysis Diagram (Slide 40) (memorise)

Keywords: concentric circles, individual, state, international system

- Levels of Analysis: the framework that sorts explanations of international events by where the cause is located — the individual, the state, or the international system.
- Drawn as **concentric circles**, each level nested in the next:

    - **Individual** (innermost): **personality, perceptions, activities, choices** of leaders and people.
    - **State**: **government, economy, interest groups, national interest**.
    - **International system** (outermost): **alliances, international norms/rules, IGOs, multinational corporations**.

- *Example:* explaining a war — a leader's misperception (individual), domestic interest-group pressure (state), or a shifting balance of power (system).
- Standard context: the scheme descends from Waltz 1959's "three images" (man, state, war) and Singer 1961's "level-of-analysis problem"; Viotti & Kauppi use it to compare how theories locate causes.
- → Different theories favour different levels: system-level structure for Neorealism; state/domestic factors for many liberal accounts; perceptions and identity for psychological approaches.

7.3 ANARCHY! (Slide 41)

Keywords: anarchy, no world government, system level, self-help

- Slide 41 stamps "**ANARCHY!**" on the **international-system** level.
- Anarchy: the absence of any central authority or world government above sovereign states (memorise).
- Anarchy ≠ chaos: it means **no higher authority to enforce rules or guarantee security**, so states must rely on themselves.
- → Anarchy is the **defining condition of the international system** and the starting assumption of realism (Week 2) and neorealism (Week 4).
- One-liner: *inside states there is government; between states there is anarchy.*

8. Consequences of Anarchy: Security Dilemma and Nuclear Weapons (Slides 42–44)

Keywords: security dilemma, spiral, mistrust, defensive vs offensive, nuclear tests, warhead inventories

8.1 The Security Dilemma Spiral (Slide 42) (memorise)

Keywords: spiral model, mistrust, misinterpretation, arms race

- Security Dilemma: the situation in which one state's efforts to increase its own security (e.g. arming for defence) reduce the security of others, who respond in kind, leaving all less secure.
- The four-step **spiral** (Slide 42):

6. **A distrusts B** and **acquires power for defence**.
7. **B interprets A's action as offensive**.
8. **B acquires power for its own defence**.

9. **A interprets B's action as confirming** its initial basis for mistrust → **repeat**.

- *Example:* an arms race — each side's "defensive" build-up is read by the other as a threat.
- Standard context: concept associated with Herz 1950 and developed by Jervis 1978.
- → The dilemma arises **because of anarchy** (Section 7.3): with no authority to guarantee intentions, defensive moves cannot be distinguished from offensive ones.
- One-liner: *defensive arming + uncertainty about intentions = spiral of insecurity.*

8.2 Nuclear Explosions since 1945 (Slide 43)

Keywords: nuclear testing, nuclear powers, superpower dominance

- Map of nuclear tests by **US, USSR, UK, France, China, India, Pakistan, North Korea**.
- **Most tests by the US and USSR** — the Cold War superpower rivalry as a security-dilemma spiral in action.

8.3 Global Nuclear Warhead Inventories, 2026 (Slide 44)

Keywords: FAS estimates, nine nuclear states, stockpile growth

- Source: Federation of American Scientists (FAS), estimated inventories 2026:
    - **Russia ~4,400**; **US ~3,700**; **China ~620**; **France 290**; **UK ~225**; **India ~190**; **Pakistan ~170**; **Israel ~90**; **North Korea ~60**.
- **Nine nuclear-armed states**; **Russia + US hold the vast majority**.
- Stockpiles **increasing** for **China, India, North Korea, Pakistan, Russia, UK**.

9. The Five Sectors: Lenses for Analysis (Slides 45–50)

Keywords: sectors, military, political, economic, socio-cultural, environmental, analytical lenses

- Sectoral Analysis: dividing the international system into sectors — each a lens that highlights one type of relationship among actors (Slide 45).
- Standard context: the five-sector scheme follows Buzan, Wæver & de Wilde 1998 and Buzan & Little 2000.

9.1 The Five Sectors (Slides 46–50) (memorise the definitions)

Keywords: coercion, authority, trade, identity, biosphere

- **1. Military** (Slide 46): relationships of forceful coercion, and the ability of actors to fight wars with each other.
    - *Example:* alliance build-ups and arms races (Section 8).
- **2. Political** (Slide 47): relationships of authority, governing status, and recognition.

    - *Example:* disputes over recognition of a state's sovereignty.
- **3. Economic** (Slide 48): relationships of trade, production, and finance.
    - *Example:* semiconductor supply chains (Slide 26).
- **4. Socio-cultural** (Slide 49): collective identity; the transmission of ideas.
    - *Example:* the "national rejuvenation" narrative (Slides 11–16).
- **5. Environmental** (Slide 50): the relationship between human activity and the planetary biosphere which sustains it (or not).
    - *Example:* climate change and pandemics (Slide 5).

10. Doing Sectoral Analysis (Slides 51–54)

Keywords: type of unit, type of interaction, structure, partial vs total reality

10.1 Three Questions for Any Sector (Slides 51–53) (memorise)

Keywords: units, interactions, structure

- **Type of unit** — who acts? (**states? corporations? NGOs?**) (Slide 51)
- **Type of interaction** — how do they relate? (**warfare? trade? persuasion?**) (Slide 52)
- **Structure** — what pattern organises the sector? (**balance of power? market? economic dependence?**) (Slide 53)
- *Example:* military sector → units: states; interaction: warfare/threats; structure: **balance of power**.
- *Example:* economic sector → units: corporations and states; interaction: trade; structure: **market** or **economic dependence**.
- → Units, interactions and structure together define a **system**; different theories stress different parts (e.g. structure for neorealism, economic dependence for economic structuralism).

10.2 A Risk in Sectoral Analysis (Slide 54)

Keywords: partial reality, total reality, reductionism, sector bias

- The observer begins to **confuse the partial reality of the sector with the total reality** of the whole international system (Slide 54).
- *Example:* treating world politics as **only** military balancing (ignoring trade and identity), or **only** markets (ignoring force).
- → Sectors are **analytical lenses, not the world itself**; good analysis combines them.
- One-liner: *a sector is a slice of reality — don't mistake the slice for the whole.*

11. One-Page Revision Spine

Keywords: last-minute recap, aims, theory, algorithms, levels, anarchy, security dilemma, sectors

10. **Course aims (Slides 2–3):** learn IR's **root discourses**; use their concepts to **illuminate real-world problems**.
11. **Nine root discourses (Slide 4):** realism; liberalism; neorealism and neoliberalism; economic structuralism; English School; constructivism; psychology and ontological security; critical theory; gender and IR.
12. **Real-world problem clusters (Slide 5):** rise of China/India and the liberal order; demography, climate, pandemics, existential risk; world political economy, technology, AI; gender and other inequalities, ethnicity, religion; regional tensions, wars, terrorism, revolution; ethics and global governance.
13. **Logistics (Slides 6–9):** Viotti & Kauppi (6th ed.) + *Oxford Handbook* (Reus-Smit & Snidal); **midterm quiz 13 Oct** (Weeks 1–6); final quiz due 24 Nov; group paper due 8 Dec; next week realism (Lake, Wohlforth).
14. **Text-analysis tool (Slides 10–22):** R/RStudio; demo of "national rejuvenation" in *People's Daily* (~0 pre-2000 → ~2,500/yr 2021–23) vs Zhihu; Structural Topic Model pipeline: setup → extraction → cleaning (corpus, DFM) → fitting (K) → visualisation.
15. **Student as research director (Slide 21):** question, corpus, K, topic labels, link to IR theory — AI is assistant, not replacement.
16. **Signal vs noise (Slides 23–28):** data overload; hot takes give *what* not *why*; events are symptoms; everyone uses (often unconscious) theory; goal = **cognitive supremacy**.
17. **Algorithmic society (Slides 29–32):** algorithms reorganise institutions; **coding elite** owns digital means of production; **code as law**; **data doubles**; threat to autonomy and democratic governance.
18. **Cognitive supremacy in the AI age (Slides 33–37):** geopolitical literacy; AI-proof critical/strategic thinking; anticipate the next move; frameworks for uncertainty.
19. **Levels of analysis (Slide 40):** individual (personality, perceptions, choices) → state (government, economy, interest groups, national interest) → international system (alliances, norms, IGOs, MNCs).
20. **Anarchy (Slide 41):** no central authority above sovereign states — the defining condition of the international system; anarchy ≠ chaos.
21. **Security dilemma (Slide 42):** A arms defensively → B reads it as offensive → B arms → A's mistrust confirmed → repeat. Evidence: nuclear testing dominated by US/USSR (Slide 43); 2026 inventories led by Russia ~4,400 and US ~3,700, with nine nuclear states and several growing stockpiles (Slide 44).
22. **Five sectors (Slides 45–50):** military (coercion, war-fighting) / political (authority, status, recognition) / economic (trade, production, finance) / socio-cultural (identity, ideas) / environmental (human activity vs biosphere).
23. **Sectoral analysis (Slides 51–54):** ask **unit** (states, corporations, NGOs), **interaction** (warfare, trade, persuasion), **structure** (balance of power, market, dependence); the risk is mistaking the **partial reality** of one sector for the **total reality** of the system.